

Tower Bridge

In 1877, a public competition was held to design a new bridge over the River Thames in East London. The challenge was to still allow tall-masted ships to reach the busy anchorages at the commercial heart of the British Empire. The winning architect, selected in 1884, was Sir Horace Jones (1819–87), who as well as being surveyor of the City of London also happened to be one of the judges. After his death his assistant George D. Stevenson took over, changing Jones's original brick façade to a more ornate Gothic style. Engineer John Wolfe Barry (1836–1918), son of Sir Charles Barry (see here) devised the idea of a suspension bridge with two massive concrete towers on piers sunk into the riverbed. The central span comprised a pair of bascules (balanced drawbridges) that could be raised to allow river traffic to pass; upper walkways served foot traffic and, more importantly, braced the towers against the horizontal force exerted by the bascules. The steel frame was clad in Cornish granite and Portland stone. Construction began in 1887, employing more than 400 workers for eight years.

